

AGRARIAN IRE Farmers block a highway to protest against tardy paddy procurement in Jalandhar, Oct. 21

POLITICAL OBSERVERS BELIEVE THAT THE BYPOLLS TO FOUR ASSEMBLY SEATS ON NOV. 20 WILL BE THE FIRST BAROMETER TO GAUGE THE FARMERS' ANGER. ALL ARE RURAL SEATS DOMINATED BY JAT SIKHS, THE LARGEST AGRICULTURALIST COMMUNITY IN PUNJAB

leader can match Mann's oratory skills or connect with voters, especially in the rural Malwa belt. But they concede that the farmers' ire and the perception that Mann is bending to the diktat of his Delhi bosses could very well dent his image. This, even as leaders in Delhi claim that "Mann *sahib* has been kept in the loop".

Yet, the reorganisation has reached Mann's inner circle, reversing some of his decisions. For instance, his choice for communications chief, Manpreet Kaur, was swiftly overturned. It all started in late September with the sacking of his trusted officer on special duty (OSD) Onkar Singh, who managed both Mann's Dhuri constituency and his wife Gurpreet Kaur's political engagements. Two other close aides, Manpreet Kaur's predecessor Navneet Wadhwa and media relations director Baltej Pannu, were similarly asked to leave. The rationalisation of his family's security detail—particularly the scaling back of his wife's enhanced protection (boosted to 35-40 personnel from the routine 15 in February)—further highlighted the extent of Delhi's intervention. In the past one year, Gurpreet Kaur could be seen attending government and private functions with heavy security in tow. This had been inviting criticism from the Opposition, who were questioning the growing interference of Mann's wife, sister and mother in governance.

The corrective measures have also gone beyond the political/administrative sphere. On October 22, Mann cleared the prosecution of controversial preacher Gurmeet Ram Rahim in a 2015 incident of alleged sacrilege. The decision came three days after the Supreme Court lifted the stay imposed by the Punjab and Haryana High Court on proceedings against him. On October 20, Vidhan Sabha speaker Kultar Singh Sandhwan had, in fact, met Kejriwal to push for swifter action. Sandhwan represents Kotkapura constituency—the epicentre of protests against the alleged sacrilege. Then, on October 19, the birth anniversary of Guru Ram Das Sahib, a front-page state advertisement appeared in Punjabi daily *Ajit* to commemorate the festival—a notable shift given the previous animosity between Mann's administration and editor Barjinder Singh Hamdard. The AAP regime had not only snapped ties with Hamdard, considered an authority on Sikh issues, but also initiated a vigilance probe against him. The feud was considered "personal". Sources indicate Kejriwal personally reached out to Hamdard.

In Punjab, AAP has the political space as well as time for a course correction. Party insiders in Delhi told INDIA TODAY that some of the reorganisation decisions were pending because of Kejriwal's inaccessibility. AAP's position remains relatively secure amid a fragmented Opposition camp. The Congress, despite its high-decibel campaign, could make only slight gains in vote share—from 23 per cent in the 2022 assembly polls to 26.3 per cent in the Lok Sabha election—as it watched its urban Hindu base migrate to the BJP. The saffron party, though capturing an impressive 18.6 per cent votes, remains organisationally stagnant under a reluctant state chief Sunil Jakhar, with visible disenchantment among party ranks and no clear strategic direction. Meanwhile, the Shiromani Akali Dal's influence continues to wane. In late August, the Akal Takht declared the party chief, Sukhbir Singh Badal, '*tankhaiya*'—guilty of violating the Sikh religious code—for the "mistakes" he made as deputy chief minister (2007-17).

However, new challenges have emerged for AAP with radical elements like Amritpal Singh and Sarabjeet Singh Khalsa getting elected to the Lok Sabha and gaining ground in certain pockets. At this hour, both AAP and Mann have no option but to improve governance and usher in transparency to win back the voter confidence. ■